

PODIUM

Website Improvement Specification

Full UX, UI & Flow Audit — All User Roles

Version 1.0 | June 2026

Confidential — Internal Product Document

1. Document Purpose & Scope

This document provides a granular, actionable specification for all improvements to be made to the Podium web application. It draws on three sources: direct user testing observations from the Athlete section, the Podium Full Product Specification v2, and established marketplace UX best practices modelled on Airbnb's design principles.

The document is structured by user role and then by feature area within each role. Each change is categorised as Critical (blocks core usage), High (significantly degrades experience), or Medium (quality-of-life improvement). All changes should be treated as mandatory unless explicitly descope.

The overarching design target is an Airbnb-style marketplace: clean whitespace-led layout, card-based discovery, strong visual hierarchy, consistent spacing and typography, and a premium feel that builds trust at every step.

2. Global Design Philosophy

Before addressing individual screens, the following platform-wide principles must be implemented consistently. These apply to every screen across every role.

2.1 Whitespace & Layout

- Adopt a strict spacing scale: 4px (tight), 8px (default), 16px (section separation), 32px (major separation), 64px (page breathing room). These values must be used consistently and never mixed arbitrarily.
- Every screen must have generous margins — minimum 24px on mobile, 64px on desktop sides. No content should feel compressed against screen edges.
- Cards must have visible breathing room between them. Minimum 20px gap between cards in any grid layout.
- Remove all unnecessary borders, dividers, and boxes. Use spacing to create visual grouping instead of drawing lines around things.

2.2 Typography

- Limit to two typefaces maximum across the entire platform (e.g. Syne for headings, DM Sans for body — consistent with existing brand direction).
- Establish and enforce exactly three text sizes: large (headings/names), medium (labels/subtext), small (metadata/timestamps).
- Never use more than three font weights on a single screen. Bold for primary information, regular for secondary, light for metadata.
- Ensure text contrast meets WCAG AA minimum at all times. No grey text on grey backgrounds.

2.3 Colour System

- Restrict the active colour palette to: one primary action colour, one accent, neutral backgrounds, and semantic colours (success green, error red, warning amber).
- Colour must earn its use — it should indicate importance or action. Decorative colour use dilutes its signal value.
- The current UI is described as 'too bleak'. The solution is not to add more colour but to add more contrast: crisp whites, intentional dark text, and accent colour reserved for CTAs and active states only.

2.4 Cards & Components

- Athlete cards, brand cards, team cards, and campaign cards must all share a consistent component structure. The user should be able to scan any card type in under three seconds and extract: who it is, what they offer, and what the next action is.

- Cards should have: a prominent image (top 65-70% of card), name and category below, one primary stat, and a single CTA button.
- Rounded corners: 8-12px radius. Soft box shadow: 0 2px 8px rgba(0,0,0,0.08). Never heavy drop shadows.
- Hover state: card lifts 2px (translateY: -2px) with shadow increasing to 0 4px 16px rgba(0,0,0,0.12). Transition: 150ms ease.

2.5 Navigation

- Top navigation must be: Discover | Campaigns/Listings | Messages | Profile. Nothing else at top level.
- A persistent primary CTA must sit top-right at all times (role-appropriate: 'Create Campaign' for brands, 'Edit Profile' for athletes).
- Mobile bottom navigation: 4-5 icons maximum. Icon + label. Active state clearly distinct with primary colour.
- Breadcrumb navigation on all multi-step flows so users always know where they are.

2.6 Loading & Performance

- Implement skeleton loaders on all card grids. Never show a spinner in the centre of a blank page.
 - Images must lazy-load as user scrolls. Above-the-fold images must load within 1.5 seconds.
 - All form submissions must show inline loading state on the button ('Saving...' with spinner). Never disable the entire page.
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3. Athlete Flow — Detailed Improvements

The following changes are drawn directly from user testing of the Athlete section and cross-referenced against the full product specification.

3A — ATHLETE PROFILE CREATION (ONBOARDING WIZARD)

Step 1 — Personal Details

3A.1 Country Field — Dropdown Implementation

Current state: The country field is a free-text input, allowing invalid and inconsistent entries.

Required change: Replace with a searchable dropdown containing a full ISO 3166-1 country list.

Implementation detail:

- Use a select2-style component: user can type to filter, or scroll the full list.
- Default to United Kingdom on initial load (primary market).
- Flag emoji alongside country name in the dropdown for visual scanning speed.
- Selected country is shown with flag in the input field after selection.
- Mandatory field — cannot proceed past Step 1 without a valid country selection.

3A.2 Profile Photo Upload — Add to Step 1

Current state: No profile photo upload exists in the personal details step. The profile summary card cannot render a recognisable athlete card without a photo.

Required change: Add a prominent photo upload component at the top of Step 1, before all other fields.

- Display as a circular avatar placeholder with a camera icon and 'Add Photo' label.
- On tap/click: opens file picker or camera (mobile).
- Accepted formats: JPEG, PNG, HEIC. Minimum 500x500px. Maximum 10MB.
- After upload: show an inline cropper with 1:1 (square) crop constraint. Athlete can zoom and reposition before confirming.
- On confirm: circular thumbnail preview is shown in the upload zone.
- Profile photo is mandatory — a clear inline validation message appears if the user attempts to advance without uploading: 'Please add a profile photo to continue.'
- Subtext beneath the upload zone: 'Use a clear photo of your face. Action shots can be added in Step 3.'

Step 2 — Sport & Performance Details

3A.3 Level of Play — Expanded Options

Current state: Level options are limited to Recreational, Amateur, Semi-Professional, Professional, International. This does not reflect the UK sports landscape, particularly university and academy pathways.

Required change: Replace the existing level options with the following comprehensive list (in ascending order):

- Recreational
- Amateur
- University / BUCS
 - If selected: show secondary field — 'Which university team do you represent?' (free text with autocomplete from a pre-loaded UK university list)
 - Also show: 'Highest level played outside university?' — pulls from this same list, allowing athletes to indicate if they have competed at a higher level elsewhere
- Academy
 - If selected: show secondary field — 'Which academy or club?' (free text)
- Semi-Professional
- Professional
- National
 - If selected: show secondary field — 'Which national team or programme?' (free text)
- International

i The 'Highest level played' secondary field applies to University/BUCS and Academy levels, allowing athletes to demonstrate a broader competitive history beyond their current level.

Step 4 — Location & Availability

3A.4 Availability Dropdown — Fix Broken Character

Current state: The availability dropdown displays a broken underscore or character in one or more options (reported as 'weird_in the drop-down menu'). This is likely a rendering artefact from an ENUM value being displayed raw without a display label.

Required change: Audit all ENUM values used in dropdowns and ensure every value has a clean, human-readable display label. Specific fix:

- available_now → 'Available Now'
- available_from → 'Available From [date]' — selecting this option reveals a date picker inline
- not_available → 'Not Currently Taking New Work'

Verify this fix also applies anywhere else availability status is displayed (profile card, admin view, brand discovery feed).

Step 6 — Discovery Interests (formerly Step 5)

3A.5 Step Counter Bug — Fix Progress Indicator

Current state: The progress indicator shows 'Step 6 of 5' and '120%' completion. This is a critical UI bug that destroys user confidence in the platform.

Required change:

- Audit the total step count. Based on the product specification and the additional photo upload step, the correct total is 6 steps.
- Update the progress indicator to read 'Step 6 of 6' on the final step.
- Completion percentage must always cap at 100% and show exactly '100%' on the final step.
- Progress bar fill must reach exactly the right edge of the container on the final step — not overflow.
- The progress bar must be present from Step 1 onwards, showing proportional completion (e.g. Step 1 = 17%, Step 2 = 33%, etc.).

3A.6 NIL & Seeking Options — Expanded

Current state: The 'I am seeking' section offers limited options that do not reflect the full range of NIL (Name, Image, Likeness) deal types relevant to the target user base, particularly university athletes in the UK and the planned US NCAA market.

Required change: Replace the current options with the following comprehensive list. Users can select multiple options. Each option should have a short explanatory subtitle beneath the label:

- Brand Deals & Sponsorships — 'Paid partnerships, kit deals, equipment endorsements'
- Social Media Content Creation — 'Sponsored posts, stories, reels, and campaigns'
- Ambassador Roles — 'Long-term brand representation and ongoing partnerships'
- Appearance Fees — 'Event appearances, fan meet & greets, brand activations'
- Agent Representation — 'Find an agent to manage your deals and career'
- Licensing & Merchandise — 'Your name, image, or likeness on products'
- Media & PR Opportunities — 'Interviews, editorial features, press appearances'
- Podcast & Content Collaboration — 'Guest appearances, co-created content'
- Training & Coaching Partnerships — 'Facility access, coaching deals, equipment'
- University / NIL Collective Deals — 'Opportunities specifically structured for student-athletes' (only visible to users who selected University/BUCS level)

3B — ATHLETE PROFILE SUMMARY REVIEW SCREEN

3B.1 Profile Summary Card — Required Elements

Current state: The profile summary review screen (shown before going live) does not display all required information in the correct format.

Required change: The summary card must display all of the following, in this order, formatted as a polished preview card:

- Profile photo (circular avatar, large — minimum 120px diameter)
- Full name (large, bold heading)
- Primary sport and position (medium text, below name)
- Level of play (badge/chip component — pill-shaped, using primary accent colour)
- Location — city only, not full address (with location pin icon)
- Travel radius (e.g. 'Willing to travel up to 50km')
- What you're looking for — the selected NIL/seeking options displayed as tags/chips
- Social accounts connected — platform icons with follower counts
- Availability status (colour-coded badge: green = Available Now, amber = Available From, red = Not Available)
- Action photos uploaded — shown as a small horizontal strip of thumbnails

The screen must also include an 'Edit' button on each section so the athlete can jump back to the relevant step to make corrections without having to start over.

3C — ATHLETE SETTINGS — COMPREHENSIVE OVERHAUL

Current state: Settings are described as 'far too minimal' with insufficient control over account, privacy, and payments. The settings screen must be rebuilt as a full-featured control centre.

Settings Section 1 — Profile

- Edit all profile fields directly from settings (opens step-specific editor)
- Change profile photo (re-triggers crop flow)
- Add / remove / reorder action photos
- Add / remove highlight videos
- Connect or disconnect social accounts
- Update performance stats
- Change primary and secondary sport
- Change level of play
- Update achievements
- Profile completeness meter shown at top of this section with specific prompts to complete missing items

Settings Section 2 — Visibility & Discovery

- Profile visibility toggle: Visible / Hidden — with explanation of what 'Hidden' means ('Your profile won't appear in search but existing matches remain active')

- Discovery interests: update what you are looking for (Brands / Agents / NIL types)
- Pause new matches toggle: 'Pause incoming match requests without hiding your profile'
- Travel radius adjustment slider
- Availability status update with date picker if 'Available From' selected
- Discovery mode preference: Marketplace (Airbnb-style grid) or Swipe mode — toggle

Settings Section 3 — Notifications

- Per-event control matrix: rows = event types, columns = Push / In-App / Email
- Events that must be configurable: New Match, New Message, Proposal Received, Counter-Proposal, Contract to Sign, Payment Received, Profile Approved/Rejected, Feed Expanded, Chat Auto-Clear Warning, Guardian Approval (if under 18)
- Quiet hours: enable/disable toggle, from/to time pickers
- Email digest: Daily summary / Weekly summary / Off
- Marketing emails: opt in/out toggle (separate from transactional)

Settings Section 4 — Privacy & Data

- Who can see my profile: Everyone / Only verified brands / Only verified brands and agents
- Show/hide specific profile sections from public view: toggle per section (stats, social accounts, location, photos)
- Location precision: Show exact city / Show region only / Show country only
- Block list management: view all blocked users, unblock individuals
- Data download: 'Download My Data' button — generates ZIP within 72 hours (GDPR right to portability)
- View data processing summary: what data Podium stores and why
- Cookie preferences: manage consent per category (essential, analytics, marketing)

Settings Section 5 — Payments & Financial

- View payment history: all received payments listed with brand name, amount, date, and receipt download link
- View pending payments: any milestones due or awaiting brand release
- Payment method: athletes do not pay, but this section should allow them to add a bank account or payment details for receiving funds via future direct payment features
- Tax information: link to Podium's tax guidance page plus download of annual income summary (sum of all payments received in a tax year)
- Stripe Connect status: if applicable for future direct payouts — show connected/disconnected with connect button
- Currency preference: GBP / USD / EUR (for display purposes)

Settings Section 6 — Representation

- View linked agent: agent name, agency, permissions granted, date linked
- Revoke agent access: one-tap revocation with confirmation modal
- View guardian assignment (if under 18): guardian name, email, approval status
- Update guardian details
- Permission controls per representation link: toggle on/off — Profile Editing, Message Access, Deal Negotiation, Contract Signing

Settings Section 7 — Security

- Change email address (requires re-verification of new address)
- Change password (requires current password)
- Two-factor authentication: enable/disable with QR code setup for authenticator app
- Active sessions: list of all devices with active sessions (device type, location, last active). Option to sign out individual sessions or all sessions.
- Login history: last 10 login events with timestamp and approximate location

Settings Section 8 — Account Management

- Deactivate account: temporarily hide profile — single toggle with confirmation, with clear explanation ('Your profile is hidden. Log back in anytime to reactivate.')
- Delete account: starts the 14-day grace period deletion flow — requires typing 'DELETE' to confirm — shows detailed summary of what is deleted vs retained
- Under-18 transition: if athlete has turned 18, show a banner prompting them to confirm independent account control

3D — ATHLETE DISCOVERY FEED — MARKETPLACE VIEW

3D.1 Default View — Airbnb Grid Layout

The discovery feed for all roles must default to the Airbnb-style searchable grid marketplace view. The swipe mechanic is retained as an opt-in toggle within Settings > Discovery Preferences.

- Grid: 3 columns on desktop, 2 columns on tablet, 1 column on mobile
- Sticky search bar at top with smart placeholder: 'Search brands, campaigns, industries...'
- Horizontal filter chips below search: Sport | Budget | Location | Industry | Verified Only
- Tapping a filter chip opens a dropdown or bottom sheet with detailed controls

- Results count shown: 'Showing 47 opportunities'
 - Sort options: Most Relevant | Newest | Highest Budget | Best Match
 - Each card shows: brand logo, campaign title, sport(s), budget range, location, one key detail (e.g. 'Ambassador role — 12 months')
 - 'View' CTA button on each card — opens full brand/campaign profile page before any connection action
 - Connection request button on full profile page — athlete sends a personalised message (300 character minimum) to initiate
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4. Brand & Sponsor Flow — Detailed Improvements

The Brand flow could not be fully tested but the following improvements are derived from the product specification, the UI design principles, and known marketplace UX patterns. All items should be reviewed against live testing when possible.

4A — BRAND ONBOARDING & PROFILE CREATION

4A.1 Profile Creation — Visual Improvements

- Brand logo upload should be positioned prominently at the top of the form, not buried mid-page. First impression in the marketplace is the logo — it must be high quality.
- Logo upload: minimum 300x300px, displayed in a square with rounded corners (12px radius). After upload show a preview of how it will appear on discovery cards.
- Cover image: make this field mandatory (not optional). Brands without a cover image will look unprofessional and undermine athlete trust. Use the same crop tool as athlete photos.
- Industry dropdown: ensure 'Other' option reveals a free text field — 'Please specify your industry'.
- Company description: add a live character counter visible at all times (e.g. '243/600 characters'). Add formatting hints: 'Tip: Tell athletes what your brand stands for and what you look for in a partnership.'
- What the brand is looking for: display as a visual card-select component (not a plain multi-select checkbox list). Each option shown as a tile with an icon and label that highlights on selection.
- Target sports: display as clickable sport-icon chips, max 5. Selected sports are highlighted. Selecting a 6th shows an error: 'Maximum 5 sports. Remove one to add another.'

4A.2 Subscription Selection Screen — UX Improvements

- The three tiers must be displayed side-by-side on desktop in a comparison card layout — exactly as Stripe displays its pricing page.
- The recommended tier (Pro) should be visually highlighted with a 'Most Popular' badge and a subtle border in the primary accent colour.
- Each tier card must clearly list what is included and what is not (features with green ticks and grey crosses).
- The 7-day free trial must be shown as the primary headline of each card, not buried in small print.
- A comparison table must appear below the tier cards showing all features side-by-side.
- The 'Start Free Trial' CTA must be large and immediately below the tier cards. One CTA per tier — no confusion about what is being selected.
- On mobile: stack tiers vertically with a horizontal scroll comparison table.

4B — BRAND DISCOVERY FEED

4B.1 Athlete Discovery — Card Design

- Athlete cards in the brand discovery feed must follow the same card design system as described in Section 2 — prominent image, name, sport, one key stat (follower count or engagement rate), and a single CTA.
- Verified badge must be prominently displayed on the card (top-right corner of the image).
- Availability status must be visible on the card via a colour-coded pill badge.
- 'Responds quickly' indicator: if athlete's average response time is under 24 hours, show this on the card as a trust signal.
- Filter panel: sport, level, location radius, minimum social following, availability, verified only. Filters should collapse into a 'Filters' button on mobile with a count badge showing how many are active.
- Saved/shortlisted athletes: brands must be able to bookmark athletes without sending a connection request. Shortlist is accessible from the brand dashboard.

4B.2 Tier-Based Visibility — UX Communication

- When a Tier 1 brand's feed is limited by exact-match filtering, show a clear upgrade prompt: 'Unlock 3x more athletes — upgrade to Pro'. This should appear as a non-intrusive banner below the grid, not a blocking modal.
- Show the total number of athletes available at each tier level on the subscription management page to incentivise upgrades.

4C — BRAND SETTINGS

4C.1 Settings — Required Additions

- Listings management: create, edit, pause, close, and duplicate listings from a single dashboard. 'Duplicate' is a high-value time-saving feature — create a new listing pre-filled from an existing one.
- Team member seats: clear UI showing how many seats are used vs. available per tier. Each seat shows the team member's name, email, role, and last active date. Remove seat button with confirmation.
- Billing history: downloadable invoices for every billing period. Each row shows: date, amount, tier, status (paid/failed), and a PDF download button.
- Failed payment alert: a persistent banner at the top of the brand dashboard when a payment has failed, with a direct 'Update Payment Method' CTA.
- Subscription upgrade/downgrade: clear explanation of when the change takes effect ('Changes take effect at your next billing cycle on [date]'). Show the price difference.

- Campaign performance summary on the settings dashboard: total listings, total matches, total proposals sent, total deals completed. This is a retention tool — brands who see ROI stay subscribed.
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5. Team Flow — Detailed Improvements

Teams have the same free-access model as athletes. The following improvements apply to the Team-specific screens.

5A — TEAM PROFILE CREATION

5A.1 Team Identity — Visual & Form Fixes

- Team logo upload: mandatory, shown at the top of Step 1 with the same upload and crop flow as athlete photos. Preview shown as a rounded-square logo tile.
- Cover photo: show a live preview of how the cover image will appear on the team's public profile header — brands need to see a compelling team image before initiating contact.
- Sport dropdown: same searchable dropdown as athlete flow. Secondary sport optional.
- Competition level: match the expanded level list introduced for athletes (Recreational, Amateur, University/BUCS, Academy, Semi-Professional, Professional, National, International).
- Year founded: optional but present — displayed as a number input with a range constraint (1800 to current year).
- Short bio: live character counter (max 500). Tooltip: 'This is the first thing brands read. Make it compelling.'

5A.2 Sponsorship Needs — Enhanced

- The 'What the team is seeking' checklist must be displayed as visual card-select tiles (same component as brand profile), not a plain checkbox list.
- 'Estimated total sponsorship value' field: change label to 'Annual Sponsorship Target' for clarity. Add helper text: 'This helps brands understand the scale of partnership you're looking for.'
- Sponsorship brief PDF upload: add a preview showing the file name, size, and upload date after successful upload. Brands should be able to see this information before downloading.

5A.3 What the Team Offers — Improved Clarity

- Display as a two-column visual checklist with icons for each offering type (e.g. kit icon for logo placement, megaphone icon for social mentions).
- Add an estimated reach field next to social media mentions: 'Estimated reach per post' — free text or range selector.
- Add a 'Media Pack available?' toggle. If yes: PDF upload field appears.

5B — TEAM SETTINGS

5B.1 Multi-Administrator Management

- Show all current administrators in a clear table: name, role, email, last active, permissions level.
- Remove administrator button with confirmation modal.
- Resend invitation: if an administrator invite has not been accepted, show a 'Resend' button on their row.
- Permissions per administrator: Primary (full control) / Standard (can message and negotiate) / View Only (read-only access).

5B.2 Team Visibility & Privacy

- Toggle profile visibility with the same detail as athlete settings (shown vs hidden, with explanation).
 - Control which sections of the team profile are public: hide attendance figures, hide individual administrator names, etc.
 - Fan base reach field: allow teams to update this as their following grows without going through the full profile editor.
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6. Agent Flow — Detailed Improvements

6A — AGENT PROFILE & VERIFICATION

6A.1 Verification Badge — Prominence

- Unverified agent profiles must show a clear but non-alarming indicator: a grey 'Unverified' badge. This sets expectations for athletes without blocking the agent.
- Verified agents receive a blue badge — consistent with athlete/team/brand verification.
- The verification CTA ('Apply for Verification') must appear prominently on the agent dashboard, not buried in settings.

6A.2 Commission Disclosure — Clarity

- Commission rate display on public profile: shown in a dedicated 'Commission' field with a tooltip explaining this is informational only and not enforced by Podium.
- When an athlete views an agent profile, show an explainer: 'Commission arrangements are agreed privately between you and your agent. Podium does not collect or enforce commission payments.'

6B — AGENT DASHBOARD

6B.1 Client Management View

- Show all represented athletes and teams in a clear dashboard table: photo, name, sport, level, active deals, last activity.
 - Quick-access actions per client: View Profile, Message, View Deals, Revoke Access.
 - Deal pipeline view: all active negotiations across all clients in one view, sorted by stage (Proposal Sent / Under Negotiation / Awaiting Signature / Completed).
 - Notification badge on the agent dashboard showing total pending actions across all clients.
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7. Messaging System — Improvements

These improvements apply to the messaging interface across all roles.

7.1 Inbox View

- Left panel: conversation list showing avatar, name, last message preview, timestamp, and unread count badge.
- Conversations sorted by most recent activity by default. Option to sort by oldest or by unread.
- Search bar above conversation list: search by name or message content.
- Unread conversations highlighted with a bold name and coloured left border.
- Archive conversation option (right-swipe on mobile, right-click on desktop) — removes from main inbox without deleting.

7.2 Chat View

- Standard bubble layout: sender on right (primary colour bubble), receiver on left (neutral grey bubble).
- Timestamps shown on tap/click of any message, not permanently displayed (reduces clutter).
- Read receipts: single tick = delivered, double tick = read.
- Typing indicator: animated three-dot ellipsis.
- Proposal cards rendered inline as a distinct card component — not as a plain text message. Clearly shows all proposal fields with Accept / Counter / Decline action buttons.
- Payment confirmation cards rendered as a green success card with transaction details.
- File attachments shown as a preview tile with file name and size, and a download button.

7.3 Mandatory Proposal — Brand UX

- When a brand opens a new match for the first time, the message input area must be replaced with a prominent call-to-action: 'Send a Proposal to Start the Conversation'. The free-text input is not visible until a proposal has been sent.
 - A 'Create Proposal' button opens the structured proposal form as a modal or slide-up panel.
 - Clear explanatory text beneath the CTA: 'Podium requires you to send a formal proposal before messaging. This protects athletes and sets clear expectations from the start.'
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8. Priority Summary — Change Reference Table

The following table summarises all changes by area, current state, proposed change, and priority level.

Area	Current State	Proposed Change	Priority
Athlete — Country Field	Free text input	Searchable country dropdown with flags	Critical
Athlete — Photo Upload	No photo in Step 1	Mandatory photo upload with crop tool in Step 1	Critical
Athlete — Level Options	5 options (no university/academy)	8 options including University/BUCS and Academy with secondary fields	Critical
Athlete — Availability Text	Raw ENUM string with broken character	Clean human-readable labels for all status options	Critical
Athlete — Step Counter	'Step 6 of 5' / 120%	'Step 6 of 6' / 100%	Critical
Athlete — Seeking/NIL	Limited options	10 specific NIL/seeking types with descriptions	High
Athlete — Profile Summary	Incomplete preview	Full card with photo, sport, level, location, seeking tags	High
Athlete — Settings	Minimal	8-section full control centre	High
Athlete — Discovery	Unclear default mode	Airbnb-style grid as default; swipe as opt-in	High
Brand — Logo/Cover	Optional cover image	Cover image mandatory; logo prominent at top of form	High
Brand — Subscription UI	List-style tier display	Side-by-side comparison cards with feature matrix	High
Brand — Athlete Cards	Inconsistent card design	Standardised card: image, name, stat, CTA, verified badge	High
Brand — Settings	Basic	Duplicate listings, seat management, billing history, campaign stats	High
Team — Logo Upload	Mid-form placement	Prominent at top of Step 1 with crop tool	High
Team — Level Options	Outdated list	Expanded list matching athlete flow	High
Team — Sponsorship UI	Checkbox list	Visual card-select component with icons	Medium

Area	Current State	Proposed Change	Priority
Team — Admin Management	Basic	Table with permissions, resend invite, role levels	Medium
Agent — Verification	Buried in settings	Prominent CTA on dashboard	Medium
Agent — Client Dashboard	No pipeline view	Unified deal pipeline across all clients	Medium
Messaging — Inbox	Basic list	Search, archive, unread state, read receipts	Medium
Messaging — Proposal Cards	Plain text	Structured inline card with action buttons	High
Global — Whitespace	Too bleak/compressed	Airbnb-style generous margins and breathing room	Critical
Global — Cards	Inconsistent	Standardised card component across all roles	High
Global — Loading States	Spinner on blank page	Skeleton loaders on all card grids	Medium
Global — Navigation	Cluttered	Max 4 top-level items + persistent role-appropriate CTA	High

9. Implementation Notes

9.1 Airbnb Design Reference

The Airbnb design system is the explicit target reference for this project. Key elements to study and mirror:

- Search and filter bar: persistent, sticky, prominent. Filters collapse into a modal on mobile.
- Card grid: consistent aspect ratios, generous gaps, image-led. Saved/favourite icon top-right of every card.
- Profile page structure: hero image full-width, key stats summary block, then detailed content below. Sticky booking/CTA bar on scroll.
- Typography: two fonts maximum, very tight size scale. Body text is always dark on white — never grey on grey.
- Micro-interactions: everything that is tappable gives immediate visual feedback. No dead zones.

9.2 Mobile-First Requirement

The majority of athlete and team users will access Podium on mobile. Every screen must be designed mobile-first and tested on a 375px width viewport before desktop optimisation.

- Tap targets: minimum 44x44px on all interactive elements.
- Bottom sheet modals instead of centre-screen modals on mobile.
- Swipe gestures where appropriate: swipe right/left on message list items for archive/delete.
- No horizontal scrolling on any screen (except intentional horizontal filter chip scroll).

9.3 Form Validation Standards

All forms across the platform must follow these validation rules:

- Inline validation: errors appear immediately on blur (when the user leaves a field), not only on submit.
- Error messages are field-specific and human-readable. Never show 'Invalid input'. Always say what is wrong and how to fix it.
- Required fields marked with an asterisk (*) with a key at the top of the form: '* Required field'.
- On submit: if validation fails, scroll to the first error and highlight it with a red border and error message.
- On submit success: show a clear success state (green tick, confirmation message) before navigating away.

9.4 Accessibility Baseline

- All form inputs must have visible labels (never placeholder-only labels that disappear on focus).
- Colour alone must never be the only indicator of state — always pair with an icon or text.
- All images require descriptive alt text.
- Focus states must be visible for all keyboard-navigable elements.

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10. Visual Design — Colour, Density & Page Transitions

This section covers three interconnected areas: the colour scheme direction for the platform, the approach to visual density (reducing empty space without sacrificing clarity), and the standard for page transition animations. All three contribute directly to whether the platform feels premium and polished or flat and unfinished.

10.1 Colour Scheme — To Be Defined

The final colour palette for Podium is to be determined (TBD) and will be defined as a separate brand and visual identity exercise. This document does not prescribe specific hex values. However, the following structural requirements must be met by whatever palette is chosen:

- One primary action colour: used exclusively for buttons, active states, links, and selected filters. This colour must be distinct and carry immediate visual weight — it is the only colour a user needs to find to know what to do next.
- One accent colour: used sparingly for highlights, badges, and secondary emphasis. Must not compete visually with the primary action colour.
- A neutral background system: at minimum two background values — a page background (near-white or very light grey) and a card surface (white). This separation gives cards visual lift without needing a drop shadow on every element.
- Semantic colours: success (green), error (red), warning (amber). These are reserved strictly for status feedback — form validation, payment states, availability badges. They must not be used decoratively.
- Text colours: dark (near-black) for primary content, mid-grey for secondary labels and metadata, light-grey for placeholder text. Never use grey text on a grey background — always maintain WCAG AA contrast ratios.
- Dark mode: defer to a later phase. Do not build dark mode infrastructure into the initial release. Light mode only, designed to be bright, clean, and high-contrast.

i The colour palette will be defined and delivered as a separate brand identity document. Once finalised, all hex values, token names, and usage rules will be appended to this specification as Appendix A.

10.2 Visual Density — Filling Space Without Cluttering

The current UI has been identified as visually sparse — screens with too much empty space feel unfinished and lack the richness expected of a premium marketplace. The goal is not to add clutter, but to increase visual density intelligently so every screen feels full of value without overwhelming the user. The following changes must be applied across the platform:

10.2.1 Discovery Grid — Tighter Card Layout

- Reduce card gap from the current large spacing to 16px between cards on desktop, 12px on mobile. This brings cards closer together and makes the grid feel like a marketplace rather than a sparse gallery.

- On desktop, show 3 columns of cards. Each card should be tall enough that the grid fills the viewport without needing to scroll excessively to see the first row of results — aim for 2 full rows visible above the fold.
- Card image area: 60% of card height (reduced from 70%). Use the freed vertical space for an additional metadata row below the name and stat — e.g. a tag row showing sport chips or NIL type badges. This makes cards information-rich without adding blank padding.
- Add a subtle background colour to the page behind the grid (e.g. a warm off-white or very light grey). This creates visual contrast between the page surface and the white card surfaces, making the grid read as a cohesive layout rather than floating elements on a blank canvas.

10.2.2 Profile Pages — Richer Content Sections

- Hero section: the profile header image must be full-width with no side margins — edge to edge. The athlete or brand name and key stats should sit in a floating info panel overlaid on the bottom of the hero image (similar to Airbnb listing headers). This immediately fills the top of the screen with a visually rich, image-led section.
- Stats block: directly below the hero, display 3–4 key stats in a horizontal row of stat tiles (e.g. Followers | Engagement Rate | Sport | Level). Each tile has a large number or label and a small descriptor beneath. This row should have a light background colour to visually separate it from the content below.
- Photo gallery: if an athlete has uploaded action or commercial photos, display them in a 2-column masonry grid below the bio section. This is a high visual-density section that fills space meaningfully and lets brands browse content without clicking through individual images.
- Social preview strip: pull in the athlete's most recent public Instagram or TikTok post thumbnails (if OAuth-connected) as a horizontal scroll strip. This replaces a blank 'social accounts' section with live visual content proof.
- Seeking tags section: display the athlete's selected NIL/seeking types as large, well-spaced chips in a wrap layout. Each chip uses the primary accent colour at low opacity for its background with the accent colour text. This section visually communicates intent and fills what is otherwise an empty area beneath the bio.

10.2.3 Dashboard & Settings Pages — Reduce Dead Zones

- Dashboard homepage: display a summary metrics strip at the top of every dashboard (role-appropriate). For athletes: Profile Views | Active Matches | Pending Proposals | Deals Completed. For brands: Active Listings | Total Matches | Proposals Sent | Deals Closed. These tiles replace blank top-of-page space with immediately useful information.
- Settings page: replace the current single-column minimal list with a two-column layout on desktop. Left column: settings navigation (section list). Right column: the active section content. This mirrors the Airbnb account settings layout and ensures the page never looks half-empty.
- Empty states: any screen that could show zero results (e.g. Matches before any matches exist, Deals before any deals) must show a designed empty state — an icon, a short encouraging message, and a clear CTA. Never show a completely blank page. Example: 'No matches yet. Complete your profile to get discovered.' with a 'Complete Profile' button.

- Onboarding wizard steps: each step should use the full available width. Fields should be laid out in a two-column grid on desktop for simple inputs (e.g. First Name | Last Name side by side, City | Country side by side). Single-column only for complex inputs (bio, media upload). This halves the apparent length of the form and fills the screen more naturally.

10.3 Page Transitions — Near-Seamless Navigation

Page transitions are one of the highest-impact, lowest-effort improvements that separate a polished product from a basic one. The target is that navigating between any two pages should feel instantaneous and intentional — not a jarring full-page reload. The following specification applies to all navigation events across the platform.

10.3.1 Core Transition Principle

- All page transitions must use a fade-in combined with a very subtle upward slide: the new page content fades in from 0 to 100% opacity while simultaneously translating from 8px below its resting position to 0. Duration: 200ms. Easing: ease-out. This is barely perceptible but creates a sense of forward motion.
- The outgoing page must fade out simultaneously: opacity from 100% to 0% over 150ms. The total transition overlap means the user sees both pages briefly co-existing at reduced opacity, which reads as a smooth cross-dissolve rather than a hard cut.
- Never use slide-left / slide-right transitions between main navigation pages (Discover, Messages, Profile). These feel like a mobile app gesture and are disorienting on web. Reserve directional slides for hierarchical navigation only (e.g. entering a profile detail page — slides in from right; pressing Back — slides out to right).

10.3.2 Transition Types by Navigation Context

- Top-level navigation (Discover → Messages → Profile): cross-fade only. 200ms. No positional movement. Persistent elements (navigation bar, header) must not animate — only the page content area transitions.
- Entering a detail page (card → profile, match → chat): fade in + 8px upward slide. 200ms ease-out. The card that was tapped should briefly scale up slightly (1.02) before the new page arrives — this creates a ‘zoom into’ feel that connects the origin to the destination.
- Going Back (detail → list): fade out + 8px downward movement on the exiting page. The list view fades back in from its previous scroll position exactly — the user must not be snapped to the top of the grid when returning from a profile. Preserve scroll position on all list views.
- Multi-step wizard (onboarding steps): slide left on Next (new step enters from right), slide right on Back (previous step enters from left). Duration: 250ms ease-in-out. The progress bar fill must animate smoothly to its new value — not snap.
- Modals and bottom sheets: fade in + scale from 0.96 to 1.0. 180ms ease-out. Backdrop fades in simultaneously at 50% black opacity. Dismissal reverses the animation. Bottom sheets on mobile slide up from off-screen. 220ms ease-out spring curve.
- Toast notifications (success/error banners): slide in from top-right (desktop) or bottom of screen (mobile). Auto-dismiss after 4 seconds with a reverse slide. Must not interrupt the user’s current interaction.

10.3.3 Perceived Performance — Making the App Feel Instant

- Optimistic UI: when a user performs an action (liking a profile, sending a connection request, toggling a setting), update the UI immediately without waiting for the server response. If the server call fails, revert the UI and show an error toast. This makes every interaction feel instantaneous.
- Prefetch on hover: when a user hovers over a card for more than 300ms, begin prefetching that profile's data in the background. By the time they click, the data is already loaded and the profile page renders instantly.
- Skeleton screens must match the exact layout of the content they replace. A skeleton for an athlete card must have the same proportions as a real card. This prevents layout shift when real content loads, which is one of the most jarring experiences in web apps.
- Image loading: use progressive JPEG encoding or WebP format for all uploaded images. Images must load with a blurred placeholder (the dominant colour of the image) that sharpens as the full image loads. Never show a broken image icon or a grey empty square.
- Route-level code splitting: the JavaScript bundle for each major section (Discover, Messages, Profile, Settings) must be loaded only when that section is first accessed. The initial page load bundle must be under 200kb gzipped. This is a hard requirement for mobile performance.

10.3.4 Accessibility — Respecting Reduced Motion

- All animations and transitions must respect the user's operating system reduced motion preference. When prefers-reduced-motion: reduce is set, replace all movement-based transitions with a simple opacity fade only. The platform must remain fully functional and visually clear for users who cannot tolerate motion.

— End of Document —